

NoSuggest

A user-controlled video interface for intentional learning and safer digital choice in the European Union

POLICY AND TECHNICAL WHITEPAPER

Prepared for policy, education, research and institutional pilot discussions

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[A note from the founder](#)

I built [NoSuggest](#) on my own, outside of my day job, because I wanted a way to watch YouTube without the recommendation engine deciding what came next. This paper is my attempt to describe that project honestly for the people who evaluate technology for a living: policymakers, researchers, and institutions. I've tried not to overstate what it is or what it proves.

NoSuggest is offered here as a practical, source-available reference design and pilot candidate. It is not a regulatory filing, a certification, a substitute for platform-level compliance, or legal advice. Listed on the EdTech Index (ULTID: PE8E-1F91-D7CA-4DB3-B5), a product directory operated by ISTE.

Executive summary

[NoSuggest](#) is a free, distraction-reduced web client I built for viewing YouTube content through a channel feed the user selects themselves. It removes platform recommendations, Shorts, autoplay and trending discovery from its own interface, requires no NoSuggest account, and stores channel choices and saved videos in the user's browser. It plays content through the official YouTube embedded player and uses publicly available YouTube data.

I don't present its strongest case as “compliance with the DSA” on YouTube's behalf. That would misrepresent what a small, independent tool can claim. What I do think NoSuggest demonstrates is narrower and, I'd argue, more useful: explicit user choice can replace behavioural recommendation in a working media experience. That direction lines up with the DSA's transparency and non-profiling concepts, the Commission's minors-safety guidelines, and GDPR's data-minimisation principle.

The adoption case I'm making is institutional and evidentiary, not regulatory. Schools, libraries, researchers and digital-wellbeing programmes can pilot an intentional-viewing interface while measuring usability, safety, accessibility and learning outcomes for themselves. Any institution doing so should still independently assess embedded-player data flows, local storage, analytics, content suitability, accessibility, security, procurement and national education requirements. I lay out what that assessment should cover later in this paper.

Key conclusions

- DSA Articles 34, 35 and 38 are duties that apply to designated Very Large Online Platforms and Search Engines (VLOPs/VLOSEs). They are not obligations I can inherit or certify NoSuggest against. Article 27 and other platform duties apply only where the legal service classification and thresholds are met.
- The Digital Fairness Act is a forthcoming policy direction, not enacted law. As of the European Parliament's legislative tracker, it remains an announced initiative with an indicative Q4 2026 Commission proposal. If it happens at all, mandatory application is realistically years away.
- I believe the most credible route into EU institutions is a bounded pilot with documented safeguards, not a blanket “EU compliant” marketing claim. I avoid that kind of language on purpose.

Purpose and scope

This paper is written for EU education authorities, schools, universities, libraries, researchers, civil society organisations, digital-wellbeing programmes and potential institutional partners. It's a policy and product-design assessment of my own tool, not legal advice and not a claim of legal compliance.

The question I'm trying to answer

Can a lightweight, user-controlled interface preserve access to useful YouTube content while materially reducing exposure to recommendation-driven attention loops, and while keeping NoSuggest's own handling of data to a minimum?

Product and architecture

NoSuggest is a Progressive Web App. It supports followed channels, a latest-videos feed, search, save-for-later, Kids Mode, import/export, and shareable channel packs, across common browsers and devices. Kids Mode hides search and channel-management functions and requires a six-digit PIN to change the restriction.

Layer	What it does	Why it matters for EU adoption
Discovery	Users add channels or search intentionally. The interface itself omits recommendations, Shorts, autoplay and trending.	Reduces behavioural steering in the product surface and prioritises explicit user signals.
Playback	Videos play through the official YouTube embedded player. NoSuggest does not host or download video.	Preserves platform delivery and creator attribution, but introduces third-party dependencies and dataflow questions I don't control.
State	Channels, saved videos, short-lived cache and the Kids Mode PIN are stored in the browser's local storage. Kids Mode is a convenience control, not a security boundary: clearing browser storage or opening a private/incognito window exits it entirely, without needing the PIN.	Supports data minimisation, but this limit needs to be stated plainly to any institution deploying it, rather than implied to be stronger than it is.
Backend	Stateless API requests run through a private backend worker. There is no persistent NoSuggest database. All API access is gated by Cloudflare Turnstile bot-protection. Feed loads and cheap lookups (channel by ID or handle) use a short-lived session token valid for five minutes; video search and channel name search require a fresh single-use Turnstile token per request, since those calls cost 100 YouTube Data API quota units each. Neither token type contains personal information.	Limits central profiling, but because the backend is private, full independent code audit isn't currently possible. I'm noting this as a limitation, not hiding it.
Analytics	I run Cloudflare Web Analytics, described by Cloudflare as cookie-free and aggregate.	I avoid saying “zero data processing” anywhere in this paper. I document the telemetry configuration and the controller/processor roles below.
Licensing	The frontend code is publicly inspectable on GitHub for personal, non-commercial use. The backend is private and redeployment is restricted.	I describe NoSuggest as “source-available,” not “open source.”

EU regulatory context

Digital Services Act

The DSA, Regulation (EU) 2022/2065, sets tiered duties for intermediary services and stricter obligations for designated Very Large Online Platforms and Search Engines. The Commission has identified YouTube among designated services, and VLOPs/VLOSEs must assess systemic risks and take mitigation measures, which can include changes to service design or recommender systems. None of that is an obligation NoSuggest carries. The table below shows where the overlap is genuinely useful, and where I think it would be wrong to claim more.

Provision	What it addresses	How I read it for NoSuggest
Article 25	Online-interface design that deceives, manipulates, or materially impairs free and informed decisions.	NoSuggest can evidence a simpler choice architecture, but I don't claim Article 25 compliance without a formal legal classification and interface testing that I haven't commissioned.
Article 27	Platforms using recommender systems must explain their main parameters and how users can modify or influence them.	NoSuggest's feed can be explained entirely through explicit inputs the user controls.
Article 28	Platforms accessible to minors must take appropriate and proportionate measures for privacy, safety and security.	Kids Mode and the removal of engagement-driving features are relevant design choices, and I treat them as context, not proof of compliance, since Article 28 applies to platforms, I'm not one of.
Articles 34–35	VLOPs/VLOSEs must assess and mitigate systemic risks, including risks linked to recommender systems and minors' wellbeing.	I use these articles as policy context and as a design reference point, not as obligations NoSuggest fulfils.
Article 38	VLOPs/VLOSEs using recommender systems must offer at least one option not based on profiling.	This is the provision NoSuggest most directly illustrates. It's a working, non-profiling alternative, but it is not YouTube's own statutory Article 38 option, and I'm careful not to imply that it is.

Protection of minor’s guidance

The Commission's guidelines of 14 July 2025 recommend prioritising children's explicit signals over behavioural ones, giving children more control over their feeds, and disabling by default features that contribute to excessive use, including autoplay and push notifications. These guidelines are a reference point for assessing compliance under DSA Article

28(1); they're voluntary and following them doesn't automatically guarantee compliance. I mention them because NoSuggest's design choices happen to align with several of the recommended measures, not because I'm claiming to meet a standard that doesn't apply to me.

GDPR and privacy by design

GDPR Article 25 requires controllers to build data-protection principles into a system's design, and to ensure that, by default, only the personal data necessary for each purpose is processed. NoSuggest's local-first state and the absence of user accounts support that direction. But a real GDPR analysis depends on the actual data flows, roles and purposes involved, including the Cloudflare analytics I run, API requests, IP-address handling, logs, the embedded player, and any device management layered on top by an institution. I haven't commissioned a formal GDPR assessment, and I say so plainly rather than imply one exists.

Digital Fairness Act

I treat the Digital Fairness Act as an emerging policy direction, not current law. Official planning materials name dark patterns, addictive design, problematic personalisation and protection of minors as target areas. As of the European Parliament's legislative tracker, the initiative remains listed as announced, with an indicative Q4 2026 Commission proposal. That means any eventual obligations are still some years from taking effect.

EU adoption proposition

I think NoSuggest should enter EU institutional use as an intentional-viewing layer and a researchable design pattern, not as a regulator-endorsed product. The strongest starting point is a controlled environment where the content set is curated, and the evaluation scope is explicit.

Where I'd start

- Classroom viewing: a teacher distributes a reviewed channel pack and enables PIN-protected Kids Mode.
- Study and library environments: learners access selected sources without an engagement-led home feed.
- Digital-wellbeing research: researchers compare an explicit-choice interface with standard platform access under an ethically approved study design.
- Public-interest demonstrations: policymakers and civil-society groups examine a concrete alternative to behavioural ranking.
- Family learning: a guardian preselects channels and restricts search or channel modification on a shared device.

How I'd structure a pilot

Phase	Core activity	What should come out of it
1. Readiness	Map data flows, document processors, review terms and API use, run an accessibility and threat assessment, and name a responsible owner.	An approved pilot dossier, a risk register, and public claims that hold up to scrutiny.
2. Controlled pilot	A small opt-in cohort, curated content, configured devices, a support channel, and a safeguarding and incident process.	Operational findings, without unsupported learning or wellbeing claims.
3. Independent evaluation	Measure task completion, unwanted navigation, watch-session length, accessibility, user control and support burden.	A reproducible report with limitations stated and no causal overclaiming.
4. Scale decision	Assess localisation, DPIA need, procurement, support model, licensing, security assurance and vendor dependencies.	A go/no-go decision made by the institution and its accountable leadership, not by me.
5. Ongoing governance	Versioned architecture, a change log, annual legal review, vulnerability handling, and telemetry review.	A maintained evidence pack and transparent release notes.

Risk register and safeguards

I'd rather list the risks myself than have someone else find them first.

Risk	What could actually go wrong	What I'm doing about it
YouTube dependency	NoSuggest just wraps YouTube's own video player. I don't control the ads it shows, whether a video gets taken down, or where "watch next" links inside the player lead.	Say this limitation out loud rather than hide it. Suggest device-level settings where they help. Have a backup plan for when a video won't load.
Third-party data flows	Some basic technical info, like your rough location and what you searched for, briefly passes through Cloudflare and YouTube's systems, since that's just how the internet works. Cloudflare Turnstile also processes browser signals (IP address, browser characteristics) to distinguish human users from automated scripts. NoSuggest does not receive those signals directly.	Write down exactly what goes where. Explain it plainly in a privacy notice. Check my contracts with those companies. Do a basic privacy risk check (a DPIA). Cloudflare Turnstile is disclosed in the privacy policy and the DPIA. Its use is proportionate: expensive API calls require a fresh per-request token; cheaper calls reuse a five-minute session token. Neither token contains personal information.
Content suitability	Removing recommendations doesn't make selected content accurate, age-appropriate or lawful.	Rely on a real person curating the channel list. Review content regularly. Give people a way to report and remove something bad.
The Kids Mode PIN isn't real security	It's a soft deterrent, not a lock. Clearing the browser's data or opening a private window skips it entirely, no PIN needed.	Be upfront that it's a deterrent for casual use, not a security feature. Give a way to reset it. Tell schools & parents plainly what it can't do.
Accessibility	A simple, distraction-free design still needs to work for someone using only a keyboard, a screen reader, or captions.	Test it against the standard accessibility benchmark (WCAG 2.2 AA). Write down the results. Fix what's found.
Security and supply chain	Like any piece of software, new bugs or weaknesses can show up as things change.	Keep a security policy. Regularly check for known vulnerabilities in the tools I rely on. Give people a clear way to report a problem.
Licensing and auditability	Because the backend code is private, nobody outside can independently check everything I say about it.	Publish exactly what the license does and doesn't allow. Give trusted reviewers special access if an institution needs to verify something.
Evidence overclaiming	Benefit claims can become misleading without controlled studies.	I separate design facts, user feedback and causal research claims, and I publish methods and limitations alongside any of the latter.

How I describe NoSuggest publicly

Short description

NoSuggest is a free, source-available, distraction-reduced interface for watching YouTube through channels and searches chosen by the user. It removes recommendations, Shorts, autoplay and trending discovery from the NoSuggest experience, stores user selections locally, and plays content through YouTube's official embedded player. I offer it as a practical reference design for explicit-choice, data-minimised media access, not as a substitute for YouTube's obligations and not as an EU compliance certificate.

Claims I avoid

- “EU approved” or “DSA certified.”
- “Fully open source.” Not accurate while the backend stays private.
- “Zero data processing.” Not accurate while Cloudflare analytics runs.
- “Guaranteed safe for children.”
- “Proven to improve learning, attention or mental health” without independent evidence.

Conclusion

I think NoSuggest makes a credible, if small, contribution to EU debates about user agency, non-behavioural feeds, privacy-conscious architecture, and excessive-use design features. Its practical value is in showing that access to online video can be organised around explicit choices instead of personalised recommendations, not in claiming to have solved a regulatory problem that belongs to much larger platforms.

The route I'm taking toward institutional adoption is disciplined evidence: accurate product claims, transparent third-party dependencies, child-safety and accessibility testing, privacy and security documentation, and bounded pilots with real institutions. Done that way, I believe NoSuggest can be a useful demonstrator and an optional educational tool, without making the legal error of presenting itself as a platform-level DSA or future-DFA compliance solution.

References

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